

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called 'The Ground of the Buddhas'

Ārya-buddhabūmi-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 275 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་གྱི་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛོད་

Toh 275 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as "The Ground of the Buddhas," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-buddhabūmi-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra, and in Tibetan as Phags pa sangs rgyas kyi sa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo. It belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras and concerns the exalted domain or ground of a fully awakened buddha — the qualities, purified consciousness, and transcendent abode that characterize buddhahood itself. The text opens with the Buddha dwelling in a resplendent palace blazing with the seven precious substances, radiating light throughout immeasurable world-systems, and proceeds to describe the nature of that ground as utterly pure, sovereign awareness completely beyond the three realms. As one of the shorter but doctrinally significant sūtras in the Kangyur, it provided foundational material for later scholastic treatises on the attributes of buddhahood, most notably the Buddhabūmisūtra-śāstra tradition.

In the language of India: Ārya-buddhabūmi-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called "The Ground of the Buddhas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in a great palace, arrayed and blazing in its supreme splendor with the seven precious substances, from which great rays of light streamed forth filling immeasurable world-systems in their fullness. Distinct and utterly differentiated places, measureless and perfectly arrayed, their expanse unbroken. The domain of activity completely transcending all three realms. Arisen from the roots of virtue of that teacher who transcends the world. Possessing the characteristic of consciousness that is utterly pure and sovereign. The abode of the Tathāgata. Attended by a Saṅgha of innumerable bodhisattvas. Moving through it without limit were gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and great serpents, together with Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), Brahmā, the protectors of the world, humans, and non-humans in immeasurable number. Steadfast in the great joy and bliss of the taste of Dharma. Dwelling there, ready to perfectly accomplish every aim of all

sentient beings. Entirely free from all harm arising from the stains of affliction. Having utterly abandoned all mārās. Surpassing all arrays. Adorned by the blessings of the Tathāgata. Being those who emerge through mindfulness, intelligence, and great realization. Being those who ride the great vehicle of calm abiding and special insight, and who enter through the great gateway of liberation, which is emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness. Abiding there, seated upon an arrangement resting on the lotus king of great precious jewels, adorned with an immeasurable gathering of qualities.

The Blessed One, endowed with a mind of perfect comprehension, free from the duality of going about in all things, supremely inclined toward phenomena without defining characteristics, abiding in the abiding of the buddhas, having attained equality with all buddhas, having attained unobscured realization, endowed with the quality of irreversibility, not carried away by the domain of objects, established in what is inconceivable, having perfected equality with the three times, endowed with a body that enters into all world-systems, possessed of knowledge without doubt regarding all phenomena, possessed of an intelligence endowed with all modes of conduct, without hesitation in knowing the Dharma, endowed with a body free from conceptual examination, with wisdom perfectly received by all bodhisattvas, having come to the supreme other shore of the non-dual abiding of the buddhas, having reached the consummation of the wisdom that causes the Tathāgata's distinctive liberation, having fully comprehended the equality of the buddhas who are without limit or center, possessing the noble dharmadhātu, touching the very boundary of the expanse of space, reaching to the furthest end of future time —

Together with this were all the immeasurable śrāvaka Saṅghas who had direct knowledge: sons of the buddhas, perfectly liberated in mind, perfectly liberated in wisdom, supremely pure in moral discipline, meeting happiness and those who desire the Dharma, with great learning, who hold what they have heard, who have gathered what they have heard, who think and reflect well, who speak and express well, who perform wholesome actions well; possessed of swift wisdom, of quick wisdom, of sharp wisdom, of the wisdom of definite emergence, of the wisdom of definite realization; possessing great wisdom, vast wisdom, profound wisdom, matchless wisdom, wisdom endowed with jewel-like qualities; endowed with the three forms of higher knowledge; having attained the supreme good of abiding in happiness in this very life.

great in thoroughly purifying the faculties; with a manner of conduct supremely at peace; endowed with excellence; possessed of great patience and great joy; utterly devoted to the word of the Tathāgata; those who had gathered in great assembly — along with countless other great bodhisattvas, great beings (mahāsattvas) gathered from different buddha fields — all of them had entered perfectly into the great stage, had emerged definitively through the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, held an equal mind toward all sentient beings, were free from all conceptual thought in both eons and non-eons, had definitively overcome all attacks of Māra, had gone far beyond all mental engagement with the paths of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, were steadied by the joy and bliss of the great taste of the Dharma, had passed completely beyond the five fears, were those who had traversed the irreversible stage as one unified path, and were present on the ground that utterly pacifies all harm to all sentient beings — all of them were there together.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Most Gathered:

Most Gathered, the ground of a buddha is comprised of five qualities. What are those five? They are these: the pure dharmadhātu, mirror-like wisdom, the wisdom of equality, the wisdom of individual discernment, and the wisdom of accomplishing activities.

Most Gathered, the pure dharmadhātu is like this: take, for example, space — it is present throughout all the manifold forms that have taken shape as material things, yet it is not expressed by them and is not manifold; it is of one taste. In the same way, the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas is present throughout all the manifold forms of objects of knowledge, yet it is not expressed by them and is not manifold; it is of one taste.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: although it pervades without distinction all things that have taken shape as forms, it is not stained by the faults of form. In the same way, the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, although it pervades without distinction all sentient beings through its thorough establishment of the equality of mind, is not stained by the faults of sentient beings.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: although it opens the way for all that arises as actions of body, speech, and mind, space itself has no exertion and no deliberate construction. In the same way, the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, although it opens the way for all wisdom, all emanation, and all

the activities that benefit sentient beings, the pure dharmadhātu itself has no exertion and no deliberate construction.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: in space the arising of forms of various kinds appears, and their perishing appears, yet space itself neither arises nor perishes. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, the arising of all wisdom, all emanation, and all the activities that benefit sentient beings appears, and their perishing appears, yet the pure dharmadhātu itself neither arises nor perishes.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: in space the waxing of the many and various forms appears, and their waning appears, yet in space itself there is neither waxing nor waning. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, the waxing of the essential teaching of the Tathāgata appears, and its decline appears, yet the pure dharmadhātu itself neither waxes nor wanes.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: because space is without limit, the forms that exist in the ten directions throughout space are boundless and without end, yet space itself does not go or come or move or

stir or move. In the same way, because the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas is without limit, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas the boundless and endless acts of benefiting all sentient beings in the ten directions and establishing them in their respective well-being appear, yet the pure dharmadhātu itself does not go or come or stir or move.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: in space the destruction of the great trichiliocosm appears, and its formation appears, yet space itself neither is destroyed nor is formed. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, the appearances of innumerable perfect and complete awakenings in every aspect and of complete passages into nirvāṇa appear, yet in the pure dharmadhātu itself there is neither a perfect and complete awakening nor a complete passing into nirvāṇa.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: in space, illumination, wetness, burning, drying, and all manner of changes appear in things that are material and supported by space, yet space itself is not altered by these, nor is it wearied by them. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, many kinds of wrong formations of training and of bodily, verbal, and mental action appear in the realm of sentient beings that are supported by it, yet the pure dharmadhātu is not altered by these, nor is it wearied by

them.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: the great earth appears in space, and great mountains appear, and fire, and light, and birds in flight, and the sun and moon moving — and yet space itself is not the characteristic of any of these. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, the aggregates of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the wisdom of the vision of liberation appear, yet the pure dharmadhātu itself is not the characteristic of any of these.

Most Gathered, take, for example, space: in space there appear the innumerable world-system maṇḍalas of the great trichiliocosm, assembled through various causes and conditions, yet in all this space exerts no effort and performs no deliberate formation. In the same way, in the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, there appear innumerable magnificent maṇḍalas of buddha-retinues complete in every aspect, yet in the pure dharmadhātu itself there is no effort and no deliberate formation.

Most Gathered, mirror-like wisdom (Skt. ādarśajñāna) is like this: just as reflections appear in dependence upon the disc of a mirror, so too reflections of consciousness at the sense bases and their objects appear in dependence upon the disc of the mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas. Therefore, the disc of the mirror and the disc of mirror-like wisdom are equal in their equality, and for that reason this wisdom is called mirror-like wisdom. And so the disc of a mirror is to be understood as its analogy.

Most Gathered, take, for example, a man who desires merit and who has a great mirror-disc placed without moving in a fine spot, so that however many ordinary people come and gather there, each one may separately examine the flaws and virtues of his own body — by doing so, flaws are cleared away and virtues come to be cultivated.

Just so, the disc of mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas is placed without moving, in unbroken continuity, in the perfectly pure abode of the dharmadhātu, so that it may separately discern the affliction and purification of however many innumerable and countless sentient beings there may be — and by doing so, affliction is cleared away and purification comes to be cultivated.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: a mirror-disc that has been very finely polished, bright and utterly clear, without any tarnish, shines and gleams and blazes forth everywhere, completely luminous. Just so, the disc of mirror-like

wisdom of the Tathāgatas — the wisdom of the buddhas purified of the stains of the afflictive obscuration and the cognitive obscuration, thoroughly refined, held firm by the meditative absorption that depends upon it — is bright and utterly clear, without any tarnish, and because it is the very thing that accomplishes the welfare of all sentient beings, it shines and gleams and blazes forth, completely luminous.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the disc of a mirror becomes, in dependence upon the condition of forms presented to it, the cause from which many and various reflections arise. Just so, the disc of mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas also becomes, in dependence upon the condition of the moment afforded by sentient beings, the cause from which many and various reflections of wisdom arise.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: although many, various, and manifold reflections appear in the disc of a mirror, those reflections do not exist within that mirror-disc itself — for within it the mirror-disc exerts no effort and performs no deliberate construction. Just so, although many, various, and manifold reflections of cognition arise within the disc of mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas, those reflections of cognition do not exist within that disc of mirror-like wisdom itself — for within it that disc of mirror-like wisdom exerts no effort and performs no deliberate construction.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the disc of a mirror is neither identical with those many, various, and manifold reflections, nor is it separate from them — because it is proximate to them and is their cause. Just so, the disc of mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas is neither identical with those many, various, and manifold reflections of cognition, nor is it separate from them — because it is of a nature that is proximate to them and free from any forgetfulness with regard to them.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: a mirror-disc that has been well polished on all its surfaces becomes the cause from which reflections arise on the front, on the sides, on the back, and from every direction. Just so, the disc of mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas — entirely unbroken, of immeasurable scope, and thoroughly refined — becomes from every side the cause from which reflections of cognition arise: namely, the reflections of cognition belonging to the vehicle of the śrāvakas, for the sake of leading those of the śrāvaka vehicle to liberation by the śrāvaka vehicle; the reflections of cognition belonging to the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, for the sake of

leading those of the pratyekabuddha vehicle to liberation by the pratyekabuddha vehicle; and the reflections of cognition belonging to the Great Vehicle, for the sake of leading those of the Great Vehicle to liberation by the Great Vehicle.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: in the disc of a mirror there appear such things as earth, mountains, trees, dwellings,

and the reflection of a great palace appear — great reflections appear, and yet the disc of the mirror is not expanded to that size. In the same way, within the disc of the mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas, reflections of the wisdom of all the bodhisattva grounds, from the first ground up through the buddha ground, also appear; reflections of the cognition of all worldly and transcendent phenomena also appear; and within the mirror-like wisdom there is no boundary that is ever exhausted.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the disc of a mirror does not become the cause for reflections to arise of forms that are obscured by other forms. In the same way, the disc of the mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas does not become the cause for reflections of wisdom to arise in sentient beings who are held by evil companions and obscured by listening to what is not the sacred Dharma — because they are not suitable vessels.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the disc of a mirror does not become the cause for reflections to arise of forms placed within darkness. In the same way, the disc of the mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas does not become the cause for reflections of wisdom to arise in sentient beings who delight in wrongful conduct and have entered into the darkness of ignorance — because they are not suitable vessels.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the disc of a mirror does not become the cause for reflections to arise of forms located at a distance of many leagues. In the same way, the disc of the mirror-like wisdom of the Tathāgatas does not become the cause for reflections of wisdom to arise in sentient beings who dwell in impure karma that will bring them to destitution in the sacred Dharma, and who lack great aspiration — because they are not suitable vessels.

Most Gathered, the wisdom of sameness (Skt. samatājñāna) is to be understood as perfectly accomplished in ten aspects: the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness with respect to characteristics and sovereignty and joy; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in the

experience of dependent origination; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in being free from characteristics, as being without characteristic; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in great loving-kindness of the aspect of universal protection; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in great compassion of the aspect of never abandoning; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in showing a form body of every kind to all sentient beings according to their aspirations; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in speech that is worthy to be received by all sentient beings; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in being of one taste with the pacification of the world; the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in being of one taste between pleasure and suffering in the phenomena of the world; and the perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in the supreme development of qualities.

Most Gathered, the discerning wisdom (Skt. *pratyavekṣaṇājñāna*) is like this: just as the world-realm is the dwelling-place of the realm of sentient beings, so too the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas is the dwelling-place of all buddha qualities — of meditative absorption, of the gateways of *dhāraṇī*, of individual perfect knowledge, of eloquence, of teaching, and of all the qualities of a buddha.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the world-realm is the cause for the simultaneous arising of the manifold and variegated cognitions of sentient beings.

In the same way, the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas is the cause for the simultaneous arising of the manifold and variegated cognitions of the wisdom that is unobstructed with respect to all objects of knowledge.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the world-realm is resplendent and luminous, utterly radiant, adorned with manifold and variegated groves of delight, forests, and lovely pools. In the same way, the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas is likewise resplendent and luminous, utterly radiant, adorned with manifold and variegated splendors — the perfections, the Dharmas concordant with the factors of awakening, the powers, the fearlessnesses, and the unshared qualities of a buddha.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the world-realm presents this appearance — the continents, the moon, the sun, the realm of the Four Great Kings, the Thirty-Three, the realm Free from Strife, *Tuṣita*, the realm of Delight in Magical Creation, the realm of Mastery over Others' Creations, the *Brahmā*

realms, and so forth — all appearing as thoroughly differentiated aspects. In the same way, the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas likewise presents the appearance of thoroughly differentiated aspects, discerning without remainder all of the following — worldly excellence and excellence that transcends the world, decline, cause and effect together, and the complete and perfect realization of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the world-realm becomes a great wealth and enjoyment for sentient beings. In the same way, the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas likewise becomes a great enjoyment of Dharma, by fully displaying all the perfectly adorned maṇḍalas of the retinues of the buddhas in all their aspects.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: within the world-realm appear the five destinies of sentient beings — the hells, animals, hungry ghosts, gods, and humans. In the same way, within the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas there likewise appear the five destinies, endowed with boundless differentiations of aspects together with their causes and effects.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: within the world-realm appear the desire realm, the form realm, and the formless realm. In the same way, within the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas there likewise appear the three realms, endowed with boundless differentiations of aspects together with their causes and effects.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: within the world-realm appear great jeweled mountains such as Mount Meru and others. In the same way, within the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas there likewise appear the vast Dharmas that are taught and endowed with the power of the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: within the world-realm appear great oceans, deep and undisturbed. In the same way, within the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas there likewise appear Dharmas that are taught — deep in the dharmadhātu, undisturbed by all the challenges of non-Buddhists and adversarial disputants.

Most Gathered, consider this analogy: the world-realm is entirely encircled by the surrounding mountain ranges, the cakravāla and the mahācakravāla. In the same way, the discerning wisdom of the Tathāgatas is entirely encircled — without any confusion whatsoever regarding all the individual and general characteristics of all phenomena, in all their aspects.

Now, Most Gathered, the all-accomplishing wisdom (Skt. *kṛtyānuṣṭhānajñāna*) is like this: consider the analogy of sentient beings — from the exertion of their bodily actions, sentient beings engage in thorough pursuit through farming, trading, serving kings, and so forth.

In the same way, from the exertion of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas, through the emanated bodily action that arises from that exertion, the Tathāgatas reveal to sentient beings who are puffed up and proud on account of all the arts and crafts all the stations of arts and crafts, and, having surpassed them utterly, that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the bodily actions of sentient beings that are thoroughly exercised lead sentient beings to range over sense objects such as form and so forth, in the same way, the emanated bodily action that thoroughly exercises the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas leads the Tathāgatas to appear among sentient beings who have been born in their various places of birth as like-born among them, showing themselves as identical in birth, and by that teaching through shared likeness and identity, having taken hold of them, that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the bodily actions of sentient beings that bring experience to sentient beings cause them to experience individually the fruits of actions that have been done well and done ill, in the same way, the emanated bodily action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that brings experience leads the Tathāgatas to authentically display narratives of events that have occurred, narratives of former lives, and all the austerities they have undergone, and having thereby stirred sentient beings to aspiration, that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the verbal actions of sentient beings that delight them cause sentient beings to speak with one another, to converse freely, and to rejoice, in the same way, the emanated action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that brings genuine delight leads the Tathāgatas to apply themselves to teaching the Dharma — a Dharma that, through the beauty of its meaning and the beauty of its words, merely upon being heard, produces faith even in childlike beings of rudimentary wisdom — and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens

them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the verbal actions of sentient beings that set them to work cause sentient beings to engage with one another in various activities — reproaching those who are mistaken and praising and calling out those who are not mistaken — in the same way, the emanated action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that sets things to work leads the Tathāgatas to lay down the grounds of authentic training, to praise those who are heedful, and likewise to proclaim and honor those who follow with faith and those who follow the Dharma and such persons, and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the verbal actions of sentient beings that cause them to understand lead sentient beings to make the ignorant among them understand one another's meaning — explaining poetry and treatises as well — in the same way, the emanated action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that brings genuine understanding leads the Tathāgatas to dispel the countless forms of doubt held by countless sentient beings, and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the mental actions of sentient beings that lead to determination cause sentient beings to deliberate upon what is to be done and what is not to be done — in the same way, the emanated mental action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that leads to determination causes the Tathāgatas to contemplate the eighty-four thousand modes of conduct of the minds of sentient beings, and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the mental actions of sentient beings that produce formations cause sentient beings, having deliberated, to form intentions that give rise to all actions — in the same way, the emanated mental action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that produces formations causes the Tathāgatas to examine the thorough engagement and thorough non-engagement among those modes of conduct of sentient beings, together with their virtues and faults, and then, for the sake of abandoning the one and cultivating the other, to assemble the antidotes, and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and

liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the mental actions of sentient beings that produce all arising cause sentient beings to be fully roused to all activity — in the same way, the emanated mental action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that produces all arising causes the Tathāgatas, for the sake of teaching the antidotal Dharma corresponding to that, to set forth collections of names, collections of words, and collections of syllables, and that skillful means then leads sentient beings to enter the teaching, ripens them fully, and liberates them completely.

Most Gathered, here is the analogy: just as the mental actions of sentient beings that produce experience cause sentient beings to individually experience pleasure and suffering — in the same way, the emanated mental action of the all-accomplishing wisdom of the Tathāgatas that produces experience causes the Tathāgatas, for the sake of giving fitting replies to questions of direct statement, of analysis, and of inquiry requiring setting aside, to fully experience what has occurred, what is occurring, and what is presently the case.

Then the bodhisattva Most Gathered addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling in the perfectly purified dharmadhātu — do these belong to the Tathāgatas themselves, or do they also belong to bodhisattvas?

The Blessed One declared: Most Gathered, the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling — these may also be regarded as belonging to bodhisattvas.

He asked: In which bodhisattvas should these — the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling — be regarded as residing?

The Blessed One declared: In those bodhisattvas who have obtained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena (anutpattikadharmakṣānti). Those who have obtained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena attain equanimity of mind as the antidote to the perception of duality — specifically, as the antidote to the perception of self and other. From that point onward, the perception of self and other no longer arises in them, and they come to have the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling.

He then asked:

He then asked: Blessed One, may you please give an analogy by which these bodhisattvas, having sought out the meaning taught by the Blessed One, may come to teach it extensively and correctly to other bodhisattvas. Sugata, please give an analogy.

The Blessed One declared: Most excellent, assembly. Consider this example. For as long as the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three have not entered the grove of mingling, their divine enjoyments remain as things, as experiences, and as objects of self-grasping — abiding in the mode of mingling and close mingling. But once they have entered the grove of mingling, the power of that grove of mingling is such that for those gods who have entered it, their divine enjoyments abide in the mode of mingling and close mingling — as things, as experiences, but without self-grasping.

In the same way, for as long as bodhisattvas have not obtained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena, they cannot obtain the equanimity of mind that is absent in all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; and having obtained that equanimity of mind, they cannot obtain that equanimity. Thus the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling do not abide in them — they are not yet there for those who perceive duality. But from the moment they have obtained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena, having obtained equanimity of mind through the antidote to the perception of duality, they thereafter obtain equanimity that is not shared with any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha. From that point onward, the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling abide in them.

Most excellent, assembly. Consider this further example. For as long as the many rivers and streams have not entered the great ocean, they have distinct locations, distinct waters, smaller waters, waters that rise and diminish, waters engaged in fulfilling each one's own separate function, and they serve as the abode that sustains the aquatic creatures born in water. But once they have entered the great ocean, they no longer have distinct locations, no longer have distinct waters; the waters are immeasurable, they neither rise nor diminish, the waters are engaged in fulfilling a single unified function, and they become the abode that sustains the vast multitudes of great creatures born in water.

In the same way, for as long as bodhisattvas have not entered the great ocean of the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, they have distinct abodes, distinct wisdoms, lesser wisdoms, wisdoms that arise and diminish, wisdoms engaged in fulfilling each one's own separate function, and they serve as the abode of the roots of virtue that ripen only a limited number of sentient beings. But once they have entered the great ocean of the pure dharmadhātu of the Tathāgatas, they no longer have distinct abodes, no longer have distinct wisdoms; their wisdom is immeasurable, it neither arises nor diminishes, and they come to have the full enjoyment of wisdom, the purpose, the single taste, the mingling, and the close mingling — they become the abode of the roots of virtue that ripen immeasurable sentient beings.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

The suchness of all phenomena,
marked by the possession of the two obscurations —
those who know things perceive that object,
marked by unknowing of the scope of their powers.
From all who know suchness —

Perfectly accomplished through meditation,
generating the two in all sentient beings,
bearing fruit inexhaustible in every aspect —
engaged in the activity of skillful means applied
through emanations of body, speech, and mind.
Possessed of meditative absorption, gateways of dhāraṇī,
and the two immeasurables,
entering distinctly through the dharmakāya, the nature complete,
the saṃbhogakāya, and the nirmāṇakāya —
the pure dharmadhātu of the buddhas:
this is rightly declared.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One fell silent, and the bodhisattva Shin Tu Dūs, along with those other bodhisattvas, those great śrāvakas, and the entire retinue assembled there — gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas — rejoiced and offered heartfelt praise for what the Blessed One had taught.

This completes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra known as The Grounds of the Buddha.

Newly translated and edited, with a commentary consulted, by the Indian masters Jinamitra, Śīlendrabodhi, and Prajñāvarman, together with the great

editor-translator, the monk Yeshe Dé, and then established in final form.

Translator's Notes

- The opening description is an extended series of nominal and participial phrases characterizing the Blessed One's palace and assembly rather than a standard narrative sentence. The translation renders these as a sequence of descriptive clauses, following the Tibetan's anaphoric structure, which is characteristic of this sūtra's ornate style.

The term rendered "great serpents" translates the Tibetan for mahāoraga, large serpentine beings of Indian cosmology, distinct from nāgas.

"The three forms of higher knowledge" renders the three vidyās: knowledge of past lives, the divine eye, and knowledge of the destruction of the defilements, a standard enumeration in Vinaya and Abhidharma contexts.

- The name of the bodhisattva interlocutor, rendered here as "Most Gathered," translates the Tibetan "Shin tu 'dus pa," which likely corresponds to a Sanskrit name such as Susamāgata or similar. The exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain and is not supplied here to avoid conjecture. The passage ends mid-sentence as the source text is cut off.

- The phrase translated as "wrong formations of training and of bodily, verbal, and mental action" renders a construction that is slightly compressed in the Tibetan; the sense is that beings supported by the dharmadhātu display many wrongly constituted forms of ethical training and of physical, verbal, and mental conduct, none of which alter the dharmadhātu itself.

The "aggregates of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the wisdom of the vision of liberation" is the standard fivefold listing of the aggregates of a liberated one, known in Abhidharma literature as the five aggregates of a Tathāgata; this is a recognized technical set and is rendered accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "free from any forgetfulness" translates "bsnyel ba mi mnga' ba'i chos nyid," literally "the nature of not possessing forgetfulness/neglect." This is a technical attribute of buddha-wisdom indicating that it never loses sight of or neglects sentient beings; it is paired with "proximate to them" (mi nye ba, which here is used in a positive relational sense despite the negative particle — the passage contrasts "neither identical nor separate" with the reason "because it is proximate and its cause"). The Tibetan uses "mi nye ba" in a slightly ambiguous way; the translation follows the doctrinal sense that the wisdom is intimately related to (not distant from) the reflections.

- The tenfold schema of the wisdom of sameness presents some compressed formulations. In particular, the phrase rendered "sovereignty" translates a term meaning "lord" or "master," suggesting the quality of sovereign command that attends sameness. The phrase "perfect accomplishment of realizing sameness in being of one taste with the pacification of the world" and "the phenomena of the world, pleasure and suffering, being of one taste" reflect a contemplative realization in which distinctions between pleasant and painful worldly experiences are seen as equal in their ultimate nature — a standard Yogācāra-inflected presentation.

- The five destinies listed here omit asuras, reflecting a traditional enumeration of five rather than six realms, which is doctrinally consistent with certain canonical presentations.

The terms cakravāla and mahācakravāla, the iron mountain ranges encircling the world-system, are rendered by their meaning in context; the Tibetan has ri khor yug and khor yug chen po, the encircling and great encircling mountain ranges respectively.

- The phrase "puffed up and proud on account of all the arts and crafts" reflects the Tibetan compound meaning those who are inflated with conceit regarding worldly skills, and the Tathāgatas surpassing them in those same domains is a classic motif of the Buddha's display of superiority to humble pride before teaching.

- The phrase rendered "grove of mingling" translates a technical term used in the prior passage for the divine pleasure grove of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, where the gods' pleasures are said to intermingle without a sense of "mine" — the analogy is drawn directly from the preceding doctrinal discussion of mingling and close mingling as qualities of wisdom.

- The bodhisattva name "Shin Tu Düs" is a Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit name not preserved transparently here; it appears to be a specific named interlocutor from earlier in the sūtra and is rendered phonetically to maintain continuity with the preceding translation context.

The colophon names the standard imperial-period translation team active under the Tibetan canonical translation project; Prajñāvarman was an Indian paṇḍita associated with the early ninth-century translations at Samye.

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consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.